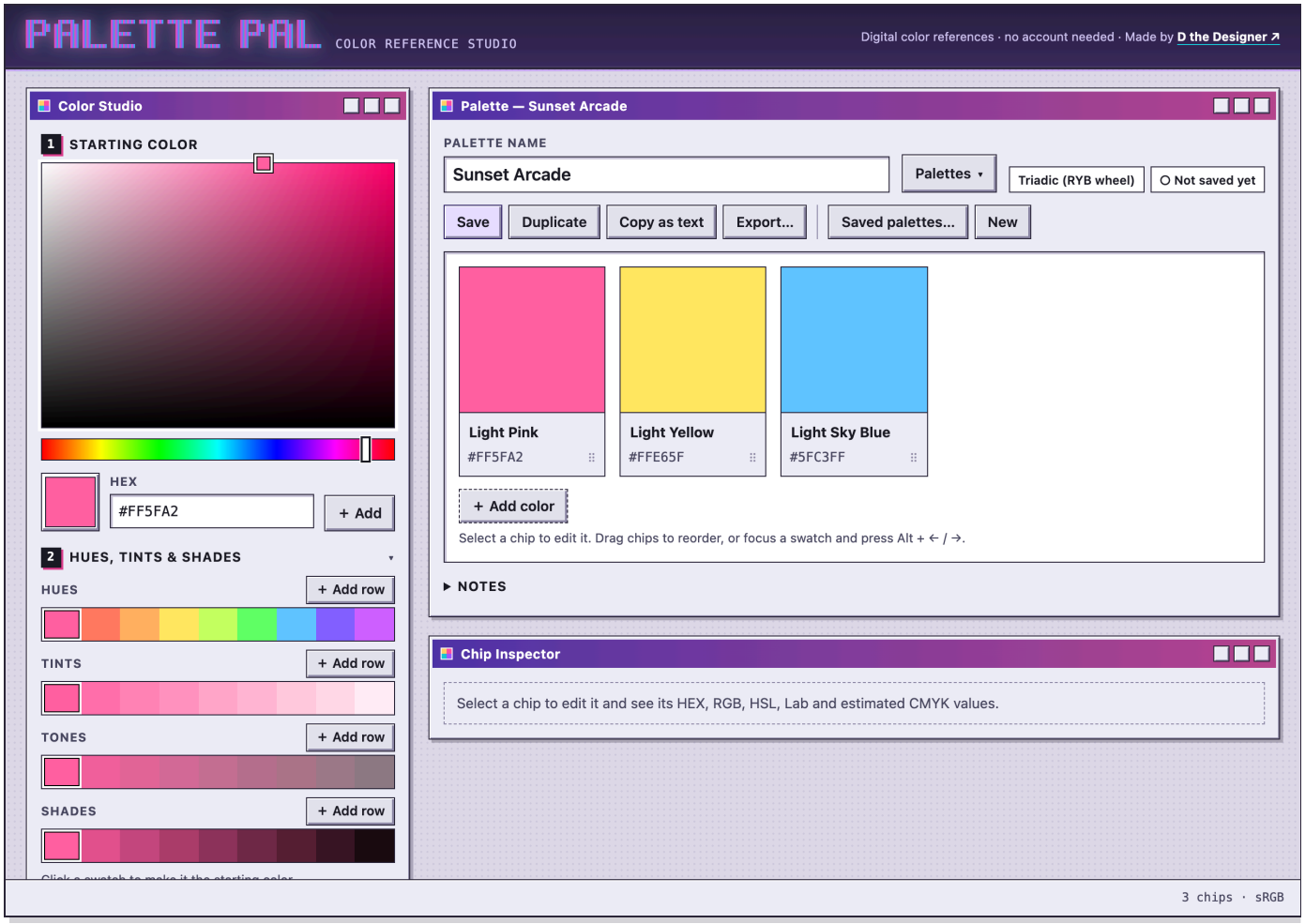
PALETTE PAL

COLOR REFERENCE STUDIO

User Guide

Pick a color, build a harmony, tune every chip, and export references you can share.



Open it at **d-the-designer.com/palettepal**
Free · no account · works in your browser

Made by **D the Designer**
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01 Quick start

Palette Pal runs entirely in your web browser. There's nothing to install and no account to create. Five minutes is all it takes to go from one color to a finished, exported palette:

1. **Pick a starting color.** Drag in the big color square in the *Color Studio*, or type a HEX code such as `#3A7BD5`.
2. **Choose a wheel and a harmony.** Pick the Artist's wheel (RYB) or Digital wheel (RGB), then Complementary, Analogous or Triadic. The preview updates as you go.
3. **Apply the preview.** Press **Apply preview to palette** ▸. Your palette fills with the harmony's colors. (Prefer to start from something ready-made? Open **Palettes** ▾ instead.)
4. **Tune it.** Click any chip to open it in the *Chip Inspector*: rename it, nudge its color, reorder it, or add variations with **+ Add row**.
5. **Save and export.** Press **Save** to keep it in this browser, then **Export…** for a PNG, a printable PDF, text values or a data file.

> **Good to know:** Palette Pal never replaces your edits without asking. If something would discard unsaved changes, such as applying a new preview or opening another palette, you'll see a warning first.

02 A tour of the screen

The app is laid out like a little desktop with three windows.

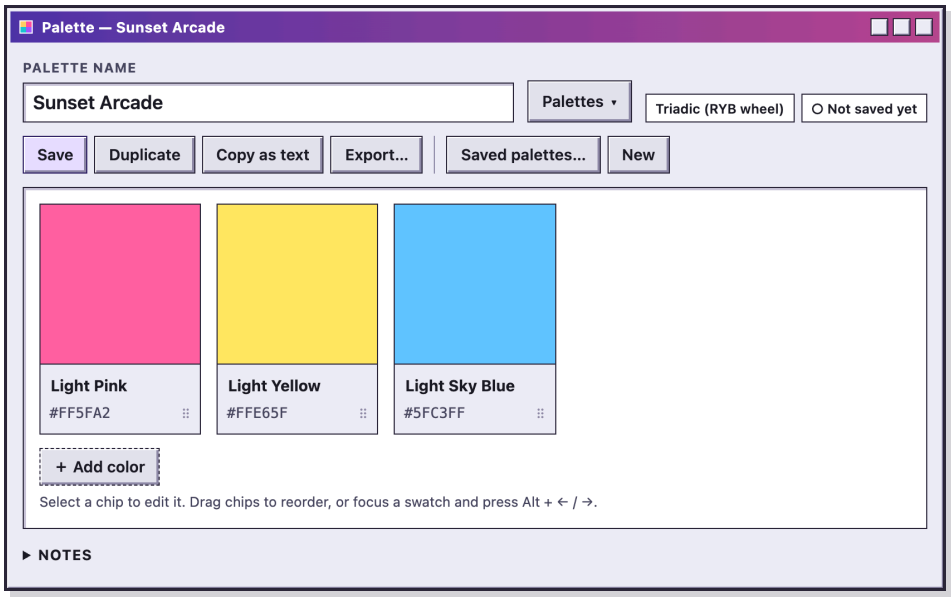
WINDOW	WHAT IT'S FOR
Color Studio	Where colors come from: the big picker, hues/tints/tones/shades, the color wheel and harmonies. On wide screens it stays pinned on the left as you scroll, so it's always next to your palette.
Palette	Your working palette: its name, the chips, the toolbar (Save, Duplicate, Copy as text, Export…, Saved palettes…, New), the **Palettes** ▾ library and notes.
Chip Inspector	Everything about the selected chip: name, a picker to edit its color, and its HEX, RGB, HSL, Lab and CMYK values.

Next to the palette name, two small badges tell you where you stand:

- **How the palette was made**, e.g. "Triadic (RYB wheel)", or "Custom — edited from Triadic (RYB)" once you've changed it.
- **Save status**: ○ *Not saved yet*, ✎ *Unsaved changes*, or ✓ *Saved in this browser*.

Messages such as "Copied HEX" or "Removed Neon Pink (Undo)" appear in the **status bar** at the bottom of the screen.

> **On a phone or narrow window,** the windows stack in this order: Palette, then Color Studio, then Chip Inspector. Everything works the same; just scroll.



The Palette window: name, Palettes ▾ library, badges, toolbar and chips.

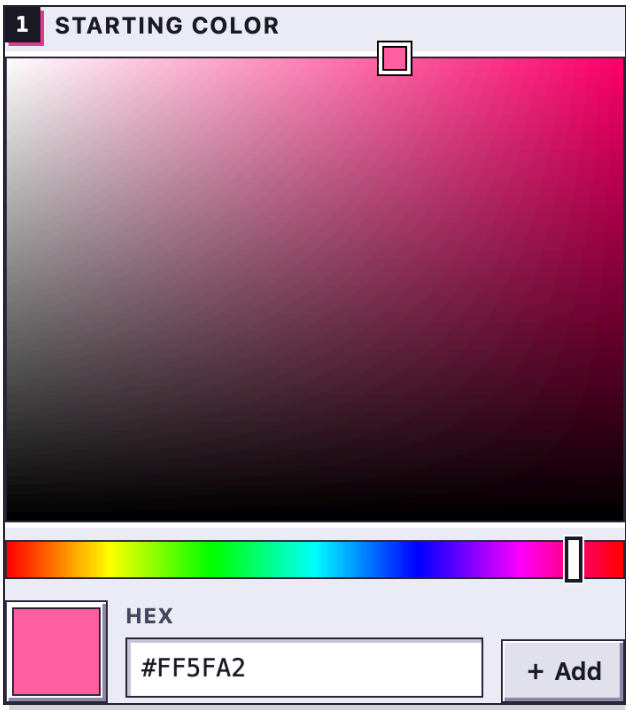
03 Choosing a starting color

Every harmony is built from one **starting color**. Step 1 of the Color Studio gives you several ways to choose it:

- **The big square:** left to right is saturation (grey → vivid); bottom to top is brightness (black → bright). Click or drag anywhere in it.
- **The rainbow slider** underneath picks the hue.
- **The HEX field:** type or paste a code. 3 or 6 digits both work (`#F0A` or `#FF00AA`).
- **The small swatch** to the left of HEX opens your system's own color picker. In some browsers it includes an eyedropper for sampling colors from your screen.
- **The color wheel** further down: click its ring to jump to a hue.

Press **+ Add** to put the starting color straight into your palette.

> **Keyboard:** Tab to the big square and use the arrow keys. ← → change saturation, ↑ ↓ change brightness. Hold `Shift` for bigger steps.



Step 1: the big picker, hue slider, HEX field and + Add.

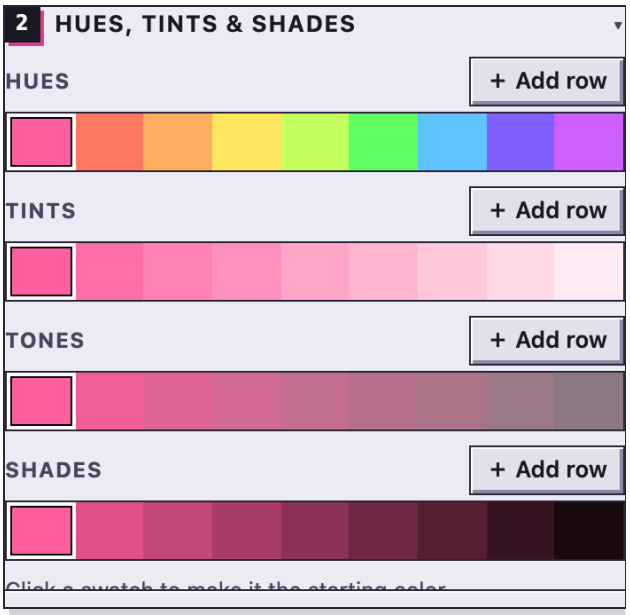
04 Hues, tints, tones & shades

Step 2 shows four rows of variations on your starting color. The first swatch in every row is the starting color itself.

ROW	WHAT IT DOES
Hues	Same saturation and lightness, stepped evenly around the wheel you have selected.
Tints	Mixed with more and more white: pastels.
Tones	Mixed with grey: softer, dustier versions.
Shades	Mixed with black: deeper, darker versions.

- **Click a swatch** to make it the new starting color. Great for walking toward exactly the right color.
- **+ Add row** adds all nine colors in that row to your palette. Perfect for building a tint ramp or a set of UI greys.

Click the step's heading to fold the rows away when you don't need them.



Step 2: four variation rows, each with + Add row.

05 Wheels and harmonies

Two color wheels

Artist's wheel — RYB. The traditional painter's wheel, with red, yellow and blue as primaries. Red sits opposite green, and yellow opposite violet. Choose it when you want the pairings people learned in art class.

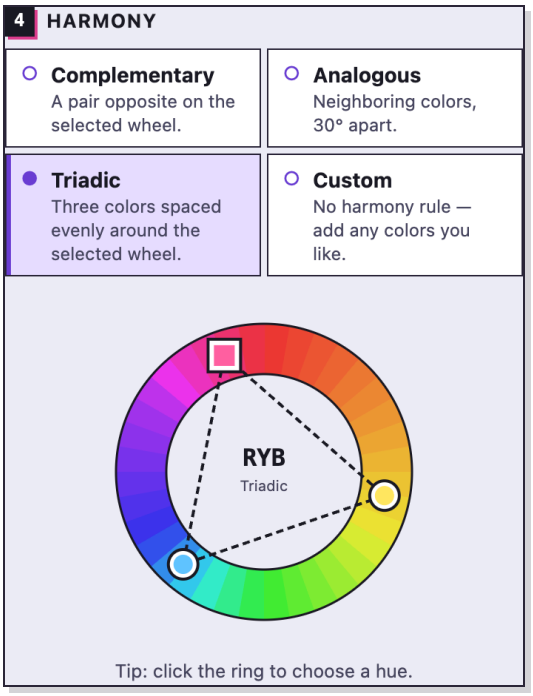
Digital wheel — RGB. How screens mix light, with red, green and blue as primaries. Red sits opposite cyan, and yellow opposite blue.

The same starting color gives different harmonies on each wheel, so try both. Palette Pal's RYB wheel is an approximation; there's no single official digital RYB wheel, so other tools may differ slightly.

Harmonies

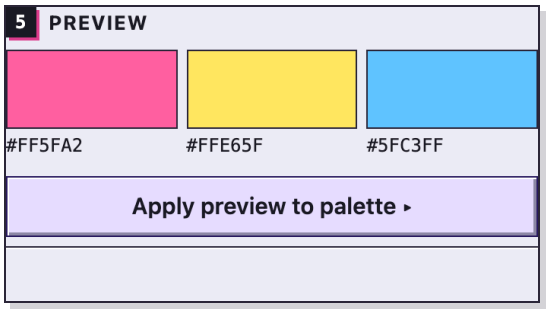
HARMONY	COLORS	FEELS
Complementary	2: your color + its opposite	High contrast, punchy
Analogous	3: neighbors 30° apart	Calm, cohesive
Triadic	3: evenly spaced, 120° apart	Balanced, lively
Custom	Just your color	Build it by hand

Harmonies keep your starting color exactly and match its saturation and lightness. On the wheel, the square marker is your starting color and the dots are the harmony colors.



Step 4: pick a harmony; click the ring to change hue.

Preview, then Apply



Step 5 previews the harmony. Changing the wheel or harmony *never* touches your palette on its own; the palette only changes when you press **Apply preview to palette ▸**. If your palette has unsaved edits, Palette Pal asks before replacing them. With **Custom**, the button becomes **Add starting color to palette**, so you can build one color at a time.

06 Working with your palette

Chips

Each color in your palette is a **chip**, showing a swatch, a name and its HEX code. New chips get a descriptive name automatically (like "Deep Muted Indigo"), which you can change.

- **Select a chip** by clicking it. It opens in the Chip Inspector.
- **Reorder** by dragging a chip, by using the Move buttons in the Inspector, or by focusing a swatch and pressing `Alt`+`←` / `→`.
- **Add a chip** with **+ Add color** (it uses the current starting color), **+ Add** in the Studio, or **+ Add row** for variations. A palette holds up to 64 colors.
- **Remove** a chip from the Inspector. An **Undo** appears in the status bar right away.

The toolbar

BUTTON	WHAT IT DOES
Save	Stores the palette in this browser. Saving again updates the same palette.
Duplicate	Makes a copy to experiment with, leaving the original alone.
Copy as text	Copies every chip's name and values to your clipboard. Choose which values in Export → Text.
Export…	Opens PNG, PDF, Text and Data file export (see section 10).
Saved palettes…	Opens, duplicates, deletes, imports and exports your saved palettes.
New	Starts an empty palette (asks first if you have unsaved edits).

Name and notes

Give the palette a name in the **Palette name** field. Under the chips, open **Notes** to jot down where it'll be used, the mood, or references. Notes are saved with the palette and can be printed on the PDF.

07 The palette library

The **Palettes** ▾ button next to the palette name opens the library. It's the fastest way to start from something good.

- **Saved** lists the palettes you've saved in this browser.
- The other tabs hold **32 ready-made palettes**, each with a color strip and a one-line mood.

Choosing a ready-made palette opens an **editable copy** with named colors, and its description goes into Notes. The library itself never changes, so experiment freely, then press **Save** to keep your version.

Close the library with `Esc` or by clicking anywhere outside it.



The library, showing the Sci-Fi tab.

What's in the library

Eras
1950s Atomic Kitchen · 1960s Mod · 1970s Shag & Wood Panel · 1980s Memphis · 1990s Grunge · Y2K Chrome · 2010s Flat Design

Aesthetics
Vaporwave · Synthwave Night Drive · Cyberpunk Alley · Frutiger Aero · Frutiger Aero Aqua · Cottagecore · Dark Academia · Art Deco · Bauhaus · Brutalist Web · Pastel Goth · Solarpunk

Sci-Fi
Evil Space Corporation · Evil Space Empire · Rebel Scrappers · Retro Rocket Age · Desert Planet · Biomech Hive · Utopian Starship Bridge

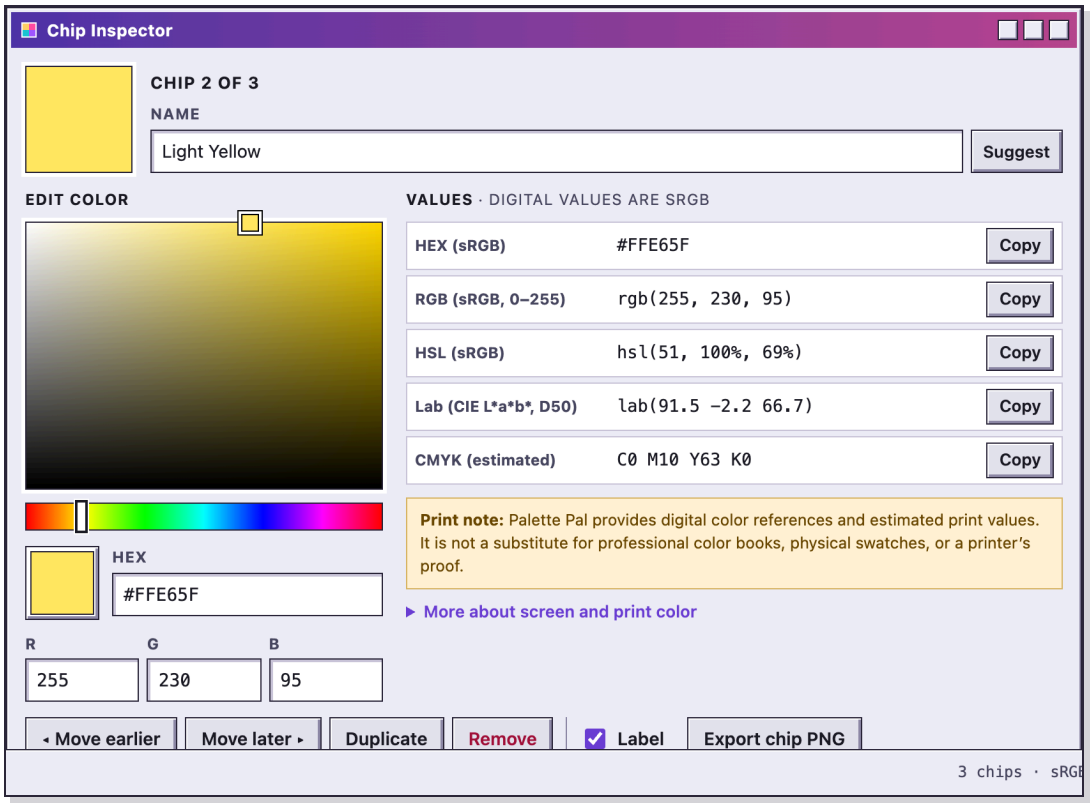
Nature & Mood
Desert Dusk · Deep Ocean · Old-Growth Forest · Autumn Harvest · Arctic Morning · Quiet & Calm

Ready-made palettes are original Palette Pal selections, not taken from any commercial color system.

08 The Chip Inspector

Select any chip to open it here. The Inspector shows which chip you're on ("Chip 2 of 5") and lets you:

- **Rename** it, or press **Suggest** for a descriptive name based on the color.
- **Edit its color** with its own big picker, the HEX field, the system picker, or exact **R / G / B** numbers (0–255).
- **Copy any value** with the Copy button beside it.
- **Duplicate, remove, move** the chip, or **export it as a PNG** on its own.



The Chip Inspector with its picker and color values.

What the values mean

VALUE	USE IT FOR
HEX	Web and design apps. The most common way to share a screen color.
RGB	Red, green and blue amounts, 0–255. Code, video and screen design.
HSL	Hue, saturation, lightness. Handy for making lighter or darker variants in CSS.
Lab	A device-independent description (CIE L*a*b*, D50) used in color-managed workflows.
CMYK (estimated)	A rough starting point for print conversations. Always marked "estimated"; see section 11.

All digital values are sRGB, the standard color space for the web.

09 Saving and your data

There's no account and no cloud. **Your palettes are stored in this browser, on this device**, and nothing is sent anywhere.

- Your **working palette** is remembered automatically, so a reload or closed tab picks up where you left off.
- **Save** adds the palette to your saved list, found under **Palettes** ▾ → **Saved** or **Saved palettes…**.
- In **Saved palettes…** you can **Open**, **Duplicate** or **Delete** palettes, **Export all** to one data file, and **Import data file…**

> **Back up what matters.** Clearing your browser's site data, using a private window, or switching browsers or devices means you won't see your saved palettes. Use **Export all** now and then, and import the file wherever you need it.

Data files

Data files end in `.palettepal.json` and hold your palettes' names, chips and notes. Importing checks the file first. If something's wrong, Palette Pal explains the problem in plain language and doesn't import a broken file. Imported palettes are added alongside your existing ones; nothing is overwritten.

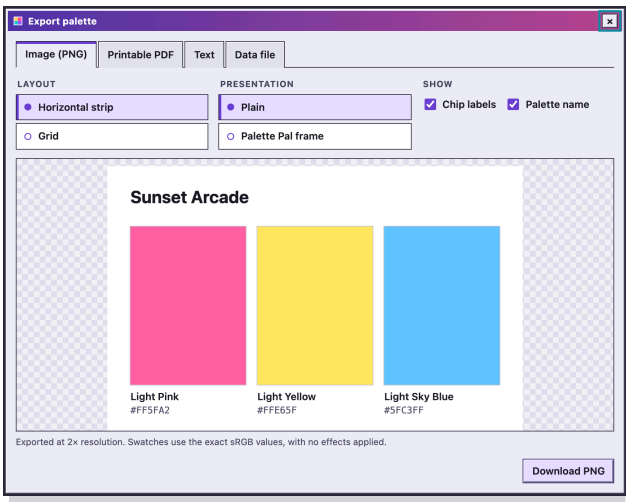
10 Exporting

Press **Export…** in the palette toolbar. The dialog has four tabs:

Image (PNG)

- **Layout:** horizontal strip or grid.
- **Presentation:** plain, or with a Palette Pal frame.
- **Show:** chip labels and the palette name, on or off.

The preview shows exactly what you'll get. Images export at 2× resolution and swatches use the exact sRGB values, with no effects.



The Export dialog, PNG tab.

Printable PDF

A reference sheet in A4 or US Letter with each swatch, its name and the values you choose (HEX, RGB, Lab, CMYK), plus your notes if you like. Each page lists the conversion assumptions and the print notice.

Text

Choose which values to list with each chip name, then copy the palette as text to paste into a doc, email or chat. **Copy as text** in the toolbar uses the same settings.

Data file

Downloads this palette as a `.palettepal.json` file that you or anyone else can import into Palette Pal.

> **Single chip?** Select it and use **Export PNG** in the Chip Inspector for a one-color swatch image.

11 A note on print color

Palette Pal provides digital color references and estimated print values. It is not a substitute for professional color books, physical swatches, or a printer's proof.

How a color looks depends on where you see it. On screens, it varies with the display, its calibration and its color profile. In print, it varies with the printer, ink, paper and press settings.

- **CMYK values are estimates** from a simple formula with no print profile, ink limit or paper model. Treat them as a starting point to discuss with your printer, not a specification.
- **The PDF reference sheet is not a certified proof.** Printed swatches will vary with the device.
- For brand or critical work, check against a physical color reference and ask your printer for a proof.

The technical details

HEX, RGB, HSL	sRGB (IEC 61966-2-1), 8 bits per channel.
Lab	CIE L*a*b*, D50 white point, from sRGB via Bradford adaptation (as in CSS Color 4).
CMYK	Naive, profile-free estimate: no ICC profile, ink limit or dot gain.
Tints, tones, shades	Straight sRGB mixes with white, mid grey (#808080) and black.

12 Keyboard reference & FAQ

Everything in Palette Pal works from the keyboard. Use `Tab` to move between controls and `Enter` or `Space` to press buttons.

KEYS	ACTION
`←` `→` on the big square	Less / more saturation
`↑` `↓` on the big square	Brighter / darker
`Shift` + arrows	Bigger steps on the big square
Arrows on the hue slider	Change hue
`Alt` (`Option` on Mac) + `←` / `→` on a chip swatch	Move the chip left / right
`Enter` in the HEX field	Confirm the HEX code
`Esc`	Close the library or a dialog

FAQ

Where did my palettes go?
They live in the browser you saved them in. A different browser, device or private window won't have them, and clearing site data erases them. Import a data file to bring them back.

Why does the RYB triad look different from the RGB one?
The two wheels place hues differently, so "opposite" and "evenly spaced" land on different colors. Neither is wrong; pick the one that suits your project.

I changed the harmony and my palette didn't change.
That's on purpose. The Studio only previews; press **Apply preview to palette** ▸ to use it.

Does Palette Pal include Pantone or other color-book colors?
No. It doesn't include or match any commercial color library.

Is anything uploaded?
No. There are no accounts, no uploads and no tracking of your palettes. Everything stays in your browser.

> Palette Pal is a free tool made by **D the Designer**. Find it, and more freebies, at **d-the-designer.com**.